Fundamentalism and Terrorism

APOLS 3260

Summary of readings:

1. A Genealogy of Radical Islam by *Quintan Wictorowicz*

2. Religious Violence and the myth of Fundamentalism by *Michael Barkun*

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A Genealogy of Radical Islam
Quintan Wictorowicz

There is not a better way to summarize this article than by the author himself:

"A genealogy of the radical ideas that underline al-Qaeda's justification for violence shows that the development of Jihadi thought over the past several decades is characterized by the erosion of critical constraints used to limit warfare and violence in classical Islam. This erosion is illustrated by the evolution of Jihadi arguments related to apostasy and waging Jihad at home, global Jihad, civilian targeting and suicide bombing."

The rise of Radical Islamism is largely attributed to the erosion of critical constrains to limit warfare and violence. Prof. Saeed Rahnema explains what this means in his article *Radical Islamisms and Failed Development* where he says: "The failure of secular left and liberal Nationalists movements to attract mass based support has also contributed to the strengthening of radical Islamists"

Al Qaeda and other Radical Islamist organizations are part of Global Jihadi movement. They are known as"Salafis" (or commonly "Wahhabis"). They believe that only they command a pure understanding of Islam. Not all Salafis are Jihadis. Non-violent Salafis promote propagation to incumbent rulers of Muslim states but are generally quiet on Global Jihad. While both non-violent Salafis and Jihadis agree that Shari'ah cannot be separated from reality their interpretation of the relationship between the literal text of the scriptures and its applicability to modern day reality substantially differ. This is a question of Content (Qur'an text) versus context in the way of interpreting terms like "belief" "defense" "civilian". The specific definitions explored in this article are:

- **Apostasy (takfir) and waging Jihad at home;**

  Non-violent Salafis are more tolerant on the issue of apostasy and Jihad against Muslim rulers. Their attitude is one of propagation and advice and as long as there is a "mustard seed of faith" and the rulers allow prayer they are not the subject of Islamic Jihad. Jihadis by contrast have subscribed to Ibn Wahhab Ten Voiders as seen below that result in automatic apostasy (where only one is required):
  1. Polytheism
  2. Mediators (e.g. Saints)
  3. Doubting that non-Muslims are infidels
  4. Judging by non-Islamic law
  5. Hating the Prophet's practices
  6. Using or supporting magic
  7. Mocking Islam or Mohammed
  8. Helping infidels against Muslims
  9. Believe in right to stop practicing Islam
  10. Turning away from Islam by not studying/practicing

- **Global Jihad:**
  Global Jihad or External Jihad (against non-Muslims) has two forms: Offensive Jihad and Defensive Jihad. Offensive Jihad (attack without justification or provocation akin to waging war) can only be waged by the Caliph and therefore all contemporary Jihad is defined as "Defensive". Defensive Jihad (or Jihad in self defense) is justified by Jihadists as akin to the Judeo Christian concept of Just War. Jihadis are "true believers" and therefore all others including Muslims are Infidels. As a result Jihadis will attack increasingly wider categories of people. Defensive Jihad is absolutely mandatory to justify such acts as 9/11 and other atrocities perpetrated by Radical Islamists. The most "inclusive" global justification of Jihad is the overriding call for the liberation of the last piece of land which was in the hands of Muslims (e.g. Spain, Palestine) and the establishment of the Islamic State. Under such premise practically all bets are off and every terror attack may be aggregated under the self defense argument which of course is always the plight of the Palestinian people, and the anti – Islam policies of the United States and for that matter all other Western democracies.

- **Civilian targeting**
  The Qur'an does not advocate killing civilians (non-combatants). However Jihadists have under the self-defense argument in reality practically all infidel civilians are legitimate target. That includes Israeli children under the argument that they will grow to be Israeli soldiers, American citizens who democratically elected a government whose policies are target for Jihad. In other words not only is killing Shi'ites in Pakistan and Saudi Arabia justified but everyone living in a Western democracy. In fact Killing Civilians is allowed under the following criteria:

  - Enemy purposely killed Muslim civilians
  - Civilians assisted in "deed, word or mind"
  - Islam fighters can't distinguish
  - There is a need to burn places where there are civilians
  - Heavy weaponry needs to be used
  - Enemy uses civilians as human shields
  - Enemy violates treaty with Muslims – Civilians killed as lesson

- **Suicide bombing**
  Suicide bombing or as Jihadists prefer to refer to it as "Martyrdom operations" is a relatively recent tactic popularized by the terror organizations of Hamas and Hizballa. Abdullah The writings of Abdulla Azzam exhort the virtues of martyrdom both in terms of the Jihadi cause the justification to kill civilians by defining them by association as combatants and of course the well known hereafter rewards to suicide bombers.

In summary the author predicts that while the increased devastating consequences of Jihadis violence may "backfire" on the movement as was the case with the GIA in Algeria, in the meantime attacks may become increasingly deadly

Questions:

1. It would appear that America's "War on Terror" is destined to failure. How best can the Western World protect itself from Radical Islamic violent terror attacks and what can the Western World do short of capitulation to "right" the defensive arguments of the Jihadis?

2. In view of the fact that the so called moderate Islam in general and moderate Muslim states in particular are targets for Jihad. Who could possibly emerge to challenge Radical Islam and prevent it from becoming mainstream Islam?

Religious Violence and the myth of Fundamentalism
Michael Barkun

The escalation of Religious violence in the past 25 years is attributed to the emergence of the New Religious Movements ("NRM") or simply "cults" like the Branch Davidians, Johnstown and others. These cults are to be differentiated from so called "Fundamentalists" who claim to represent historic religious traditions. It is easy to associate NRM with violence against both insiders (Johnstown) and outsiders (Branch Davidians) This perception of intrinsic violence as a core element of NRM while supported by anecdotal evidence is not necessarily true in many cases. The violence appears in such cases to be a response to a real or perceived threat.

A similar stigmatization factor occurs in associating a priori fundamentalism with violence and terrorism. Once again evidentiary proof exists to support the connection but it is not inherent in the concept of Fundamentalism. In fact fundamentalism traces its origins to American Protestantism. The emergence of a community objecting to the modernization trends of evolutionary biology and secular policies and social reforms. In this case overtime the "weapon of choice" was not armed struggle or violent uprising but rather withdrawal from the political process. Fundamentalism in America was dormant for many years until the advent in the late 70's of the Moral Majority and the Christian Coalition that are not immediately associated with violence or terror.

The article proceeds to examine the so called "Clash of Civilizations" debate as extensively advocated by Samuel Huntington. Bin Laden himself lends credence to the notion in an interview with Al Jazeera on October 21, 2001. In it he says that that the Jews and America will have you believe that they count for the Muslims in the name of world peace but this is a fairy tale. Bin Laden proceeds to quote the Prophet (sallallahu `alayhi wasallam) said in truth [sahha]: "The Hour will not come until the Muslims fight the Jews and kill them." Therefore it follows that this is a crusade to be fought to the bitter end. That notwithstanding the author concludes that while Fundamentalism could not automatically be related to violence and terrorism, "violence motivated and justified by religious beliefs is a sufficiently important concept in America, South Asia and the Middle East that it can hardly be ignored"

The article continues by addressing the phenomenon of "Forces of the End" or the apocalypse as a self fulfilling prophecy. Fundamentalists believe in the "End of Time" scenario and while "they claim ultimate fidelity to sacred texts the meaning they extract from the texts can change from time to time as events, calamities natural disasters occur in the course of time. In conclusion the author proposes to do away with the lexicon of Fundamentalism due to the historical association of the term with violence and terror. He concludes that "there is no simple unilinear relationship between violence on the one hand and religious variables on the other; whether the religious characteristics involve charismatic leadership, textual literalism charges of official laxity or resistance to compromise."

Questions:

1. Fundamentalism is sometimes automatically perceived as synonymous with Radicalism or Terrorism. What are the positive attributes of Fundamentalism and what positive role either historically of in the future could Fundamentalism play in both secular and religious societies?
2. How should societies respond to the phenomenon of New Religious Movement particularly when they do not represent and sometimes oppose traditional religions? Should freedom of speech and action override the threat to NRM members and society at large?